The effectiveness of advertising that leverages sponsorship and cause-related marketing

A contingency model

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This paper shows that consumers are more likely to have ambivalent attitudes towards cause-related marketing (CRM) than sponsorship. Whereas consumers share similar positive perceptions of CRM and sponsorship, and attribute the motives behind them to altruism, their negative perceptions and attributions of CRM are more accessible than those of sponsorships. On the basis of these differences, this article proposes a contingency model in which suppressing the activation of CRM's negative perceptions enhances the effectiveness of advertising that leverages CRM. The effectiveness of advertising that leverages corporate sponsorship, which is not associated with ambivalent perceptions, is less subject to the suppression of negative perceptions. The model includes two contingent factors, an individual difference factor and a situational factor. The results generally support the proposed model; the effectiveness of ads leveraging CRM improves when negative associations of CRM are less likely to be activated.

Introduction

As more businesses evince an interest in social responsibility (Drumwright 1996), marketing communication tactics that associate companies with social responsibility are gaining in popularity. Among such tactics are sponsorship and cause-related marketing (CRM) strategies (Polonsky & Speed 2001), both of which have enjoyed remarkable success (e.g. Cornwell & Maignan 1998; Barone *et al.* 2000). Their increasing importance is clearly illustrated by the significant growth in expenditures on these strategies globally in recent years (Ptacek & Salazar 1997; Meenaghan 2001a; Meenaghan & O'Sullivan 2001).

Sponsorship and CRM both commercialise and leverage corporate giving through advertising campaigns and other promotional activities (Polonsky & Speed 2001). Although both are commercially motivated, they are unique marketing strategies. In sponsoring a socially accepted cause, such as the Special Olympics, a company underwrites the fee for the cause and obtains the right to be associated with it (Meenaghan 1991). Broadly speaking, CRM also involves sponsorship, in that money gets donated to the event or cause. However, with CRM, the amount of the donation depends on the

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volume of consumer transactions (Varadarajan & Menon 1988). For example, a credit card company may donate a fixed amount each time a card holder charges a purchase or for each new card application. Therefore, 'sponsorship' in this article refers only to non–transaction-based sponsorships, whereas 'CRM' indicates the conditional form of corporate giving.

Although consumers might perceive goodwill by marketers that support sponsorships or CRM (Ross *et al.* 1991; Stipp & Schiavone 1996), some researchers argue that CRM moves the commercialisation of altruistic giving further away from philanthropy and a step closer to sales (Polonsky & Wood 2001). Therefore, CRM claiming to support a cause can provoke perceptions of exploitation of the cause (Varadarajan & Menon 1988) and cynical responses (Webb & Mohr 1998). Given these ambivalent perceptions, it stands to reason that certain individual and situational factors can suppress the activation of negative perceptions of CRM and thus alter consumer responses to and interpretations of CRM. In contrast, the interpretations of sponsorship are less ambivalent, and consumer responses to it less likely to vary due to factors that might reduce the activation of negative perceptions.

This study therefore begins by testing the prediction that negative perceptions of CRM are more accessible than those of sponsorship, and external attributions of CRM are more likely than those of sponsorship. Against this backdrop, this paper proposes a contingency model in which the effectiveness of CRM depends on the suppression of negative perceptions or attributions, but the effectiveness of sponsorship is not so influenced. With credit cards as the advertised product, Experiment 1 showed that heavy product users, motivated to suppress negative perceptions of CRM, became more emotionally involved with a cause and reported more favourable brand attitudes than light users when the company used CRM ads but not sponsorship ads. Emotional involvement with the cause also mediated the effect of this interaction on brand attitudes. In Experiment 2, ad-evoked positive affect reduced negative attributions associated with CRM and led to more favourable brand attitudes than ad-evoked neutral affect for CRM but not sponsorship ads. In this case, causal attributions of advertiser motives mediated the effect of this interaction on brand attitudes.

Corporate sponsorship

Sponsorship has been defined as 'the provision of assistance either financial or in-kind to an activity by a commercial organisation for the purpose of achieving commercial objectives' (Meenaghan 1983, p. 9). Activities that companies sponsor include sports, music, entertainment, charitable events, and cultural or art events (Cornwell & Maignan 1998). According to Dean (2002), there are two primary purposes of sponsorship: '(1) to associate the company with a charity and suggest that the business is fulfilling a societal obligation to the community from which it draws customers, employees, and investors and (2) to generate good will and enhance the image of the business' (p. 77).

Sponsorship works by generating goodwill among consumers, which in turn improves attitudes towards the brand. For example, consumers aware of a company's sponsorship activities have reported more favourable images of the associated brand, perceptions of the company and its products/services, and opinions of its community relations (Javalgi *et al*. 1994; Gwinner & Eaton 1999; McDaniel 1999; Dean 2002). Consumers in one study also perceived a company to be a better corporate citizen when an ad informed them that it sponsored a favourable event (Dean 1999). Although most consumers understand the commercial interests behind sponsorship, they generally believe that companies participating in sponsorship are supporters of worthwhile causes and events that would not be possible without such support (Stipp & Schiavone 1996).

Because the association of a company with a cause occurs primarily through marketing, Cornwell (1995) has coined the term 'sponsorship-linked marketing' to refer to 'the orchestration and implementation of marketing activities for the purpose of building and communicating an association to a sponsorship' (p. 15). Advertising is usually incorporated into such communication programmes and offers an important avenue through which consumers become aware of the association (Crimmins & Horn 1996; Polonsky & Speed 2001). Evidence has shown that favourable evaluations of sponsorship advertising and greater sponsorship ad recall prompt more favourable brand images (Stipp & Schiavone 1996). Therefore, it makes sense to focus on responses to advertising that leverages corporate sponsorship.

Furthermore, though effectiveness of sponsorship versus product advertising has been studied empirically (Meenaghan 2001b), marketers usually adopt product advertising and sponsorship communication campaigns for different strategic reasons. Therefore, it seems more important to compare perceptions of sponsorship and CRM, which share the same goal of establishing goodwill towards the company and are more likely to be compared when marketers consider the effectiveness of different corporate giving strategies.

Cause-related marketing

Cause-related marketing refers to 'the process of formulating and implementing marketing activities that are characterised by an offer from the firm to contribute a specified amount to a designated cause when customers engage in revenue-providing exchanges that satisfy organizational and individual objectives' (Varadarajan & Menon 1988, p. 60). It also involves 'the "giving" firm acquiring and leveraging the right to be associated with the recipient' (Polonsky & Speed 2001, p. 1365).

However, there are clear differences between CRM and sponsorship (Varadarajan & Menon 1988; Polonsky & Speed 2001). With CRM, the amount of money that a company donates to a social cause or event hinges on the occurrence or frequency of consumer transactions. With sponsorship, though, the extent of the donation is determined before consumers are informed about the company's philanthropic deeds. Consumer transactions are not required, nor do they influence the amount of financial support.

Because, with CRM, the size of the donation is based on actual sales, consumers should feel ambivalent towards it. On the one hand, 67.6% of respondents to one survey indicated that they felt that CRM was a good way to raise funds for charitable causes, and 48.7% had purchased a product or service primarily because of a CRM advertisement (Ross *et al*.

1991). Furthermore, consumers hold more favourable attitudes towards a company when they are aware it is involved in CRM (Barnes & Fitzgibbons 1992; Ross *et al*. 1991). On the other hand, transaction-based CRM seems to capitalise on philanthropic sentiments and can evoke a cynical response. For example, consumers might express cynicism regarding the alignment of sales with philanthropy (Webb & Mohr 1998), question the ethics of requiring purchases in exchange for donations to social causes (Smith & Higgins 2000) and believe the causes are exploited (Varadarajan & Menon 1988).

Accordingly, a company's motivation to initiate a CRM campaign may appear either positive or negative to consumers (Barone *et al*. 2000). Consumers in one survey were divided in their opinions of why a company initiates CRM (Webb & Mohr 1998): approximately half believed the motive to be self-serving, and half thought it to be mixed, serving both the company and the community.

Differences between perceptions of sponsorship and CRM

The preceding review suggests that major differences between consumers' perceptions of sponsorship and CRM reflect the accessibility of their negative associations. Whereas CRM can simultaneously activate negative and positive perceptions (ambivalent perceptions), sponsorship is more likely to activate positive than negative perceptions.

When exposed to advertising, consumers infer the motives of advertisers (Friestad & Wright 1994) and engage in attributional interpretations of an ad's claims (Smith & Hunt 1978; Karande *et al.* 2008). Similarly, when informed that a corporation has initiated philanthropic activity, consumers are likely to engage in attribution to infer the company's motives. Consumers might attribute ad claims to external causes, such as an advertiser's desire to sell a product, or to internal causes, such as an advertiser's genuine concern for consumers or desire to convey the characteristics of its product accurately (Smith & Hunt 1978; Coulter & Pinto 1995; Jain & Posavac 2004). Similarly, when attributing a motive to an altruistic activity, consumers might consider internal or external causes. An internal cause for CRM or sponsorship might be an advertiser's genuine altruistic concern for the cause; an external cause could be an advertiser's interest in increasing sales and profits. Because CRM hinges on consumer transactions, people also might infer dual motives (altruistic and profit-driven).

No extant literature directly compares consumers' positive and negative perceptions of CRM and sponsorship, nor has it contrasted how consumers engage in different attributions of their motives. Therefore, a pilot study served to test the assumption that ambivalent perceptions and dual motives attributions are more likely to be triggered by CRM than by sponsorship.

Effectiveness of advertising that leverages sponsorship and CRM

Built upon the assumptions that ambivalent perceptions and dual motives attributions are more likely to be triggered by CRM than by sponsorship, this paper proposes a model to explain the effectiveness of advertising that leverages CRM and sponsorship. In the proposed model, the effectiveness of a CRM ad hinges on the suppression of negative perceptions or external attributions; the effectiveness of a sponsorship ad does not. The model features two contingent factors – an individual difference factor and a situational factor – that might alter this suppression. Experiment 1 tests product usage frequency as a specific individual difference factor. Heavy product users are probably motivated to reduce their consumption guilt by attending to and thus becoming emotionally involved with a cause and its positive contributions to society. In this involvement process, negative perceptions of CRM are likely to be reduced. Experiment 2 examines ad-evoked affect as a situational factor. Positive ad-evoked affect should prime more positive perceptions of CRM and thus suppress the activation of negative perceptions, enhancing the effectiveness of a CRM ad. In contrast, the effectiveness of a sponsorship ad, whose negative perceptions are not readily accessible, should not change. Experiment 1 focuses on the suppression of negative perceptions, whereas Experiment 2 focuses on the suppression of negative attributions.

Individual factors: product consumption frequency

An important difference between sponsorship and CRM is that CRM requires consumer transactions or uses of the product for the donation to take place. The more transactions that occur, the greater the donation to the designated cause. This transaction association may lead to different perceptions, depending on product use. In a review of CRM literature, Smith and Higgins (2000) conclude that the effectiveness of CRM depends on a 'feel-good-factor', such that CRM 'provides a means by which the guilt of a luxury purchase can be offset and an everyday purchase supplemented by additional positive associations' (p. 308). Paying attention to the cause (e.g. helping those in need) can be effective for offsetting guilt, especially among heavy users. In contrast, paying attention to or elaborating on the manipulative intent of CRM does not help consumers relieve their guilt. Accordingly, heavy product users should be motivated to pay more attention to the cause and its positive contributions than light users, and in the process, their negative perceptions of CRM should be mitigated.

When the audience pays attention to media content, it also might become emotionally involved with what is being communicated, whether that communication involves news (Perse 1990), television programmes (Perse 1998), film (Hall 2003), radio (Smith *et al.* 2007), or commercials (Celuch & Slama 1998). Emotional involvement refers to a state of psychological engagement associated with emotional responses (Perse 1990; Sun *et al.* 2008). Prior research shows that social causes also emotionally involve consumers (Baghi *et al.* 2009). Therefore, heavy users should be more motivated to pay attention to the cause supported through CRM than to the manipulative motives of CRM. When paying attention to the cause, these heavy product users in turn should be more motivated than light users to become emotionally involved with it, especially if they potentially contribute more than others because of their already heavy use of the associated product. In contrast, product usage should not influence emotional involvement in a sponsorship setting, because product use frequency does not influence contributions to the sponsored cause, and heavy users are not motivated to attend to the cause to reduce their consumption guilt.

H1: A significant interaction exists between product usage frequency and corporate giving style on emotional involvement with the cause. For ads that leverage CRM, heavy product users report greater emotional involvement with the cause than light product users. However, heavy and light product users do not differ in their emotional involvement with ads that leverage sponsorship.

Because of their enhanced emotional involvement with the cause promoted by CRM, heavy product users further should respond more favourably than light users to advertising that leverages CRM. Crucial to advertising for CRM and sponsorship is its ability to foster favourable attitudes towards brands, which are also important indicators of ad effectiveness (Amos *et al.* 2008; Chang 2010; Chang & Li 2010; Eisend & Langner 2010). Therefore, the effects of the interaction on attitudes towards the advertised brand, as well as the mediational role of emotional involvement in the process, demand testing.

H2: A significant interaction exists between product usage frequency and corporate giving style on brand attitudes. Heavy product users rate brands more favourably than light users when the ads leverage CRM. However, heavy users and light users do not differ in their evaluations when the ads leverage sponsorship.

H3: Emotional involvement with the cause mediates the interaction between product usage frequency and corporate giving style on brand attitudes.

Situational factors: ad-evoked affective states

It is common for advertising that leverages sponsorship or CRM to feature warm-hearted stories. For example, an ad highlighting corporate sponsorship of the Special Olympics might feature an actual story of a young handicapped person working hard to compete. These stories are generally positive and encouraging, and induce positive affective states, which are likely to prime more positive associations. As prior research has suggested, affect appears to render congruent information available and thus encourage affect-congruent judgements – a process generally referred to as affect priming (Forgas *et al.* 1990; Forgas 1992, 1994; Bower & Forgas 2000). The fundamental assumption behind affect priming is that information with the same affective valence gets linked together and easily activated by the appropriate affect. Ad-evoked positive affect thus influences ad responses by priming more positive associations (Chang 2008).

As argued previously, consumers can attribute ad claims to internal causes, such as an advertiser's genuine concern for the cause, or to external causes, such as increasing product sales. Advertising research demonstrates that affect can alter attributions through an affect priming mechanism, such that positive affect activates more internal than external attributions regarding ad claims (Chang 2009). Similarly, a positive story in an ad might prime positive interpretations of CRM ads and cause consumers to believe the company is motivated by goodwill (internal cause) rather than ulterior interests (external cause). In this process, they activate fewer negative attributions (external cause). In contrast, the motives of companies that engage in sponsorship are generally perceived as positive, so ad-induced affect should not significantly alter the attributions of motives for corporate sponsorship.

H4: A significant interaction exists between affective state and corporate giving style on motive attribution. For ads leveraging CRM, positive ad-evoked affect leads to greater internal cause attribution than does neutral ad-evoked affect. However, ad-evoked affect does not influence the degree of attribution for ads that leverage sponsorship.

When consumers attribute the cause of ad messages to external factors (i.e. advertiser self-interest) rather than internal factors (i.e. advertiser concern for and willingness to help those in need), their evaluations of the advertised products should be less favourable. For example, Chang (2007) finds that those who perceive a high level of manipulative intent on the part of advertisers express less favourable attitudes towards advertised brands. Enhancing attributions to internal causes thus should improve evaluations of the brand, such that the same interaction between affective state and corporate giving style expected for internal cause attribution should emerge for brand attitudes.

H5: A significant interaction exists between affective state and corporate giving style on brand attitudes. For ads that leverage CRM, positive ad-evoked affect leads to more favourable brand evaluations than does neutral ad-evoked affect. However, ad-evoked affect does not influence evaluations for ads that leverage sponsorship.

H6: Internal cause attribution mediates the effect of the interaction between ad-evoked affect and corporate giving style on brand attitudes.

Overview of the pilot study and two experiments

The pilot study tests the assumption that consumers' attitudes towards CRM are more ambivalent than their attitudes towards sponsorship. Experiment 1, then, was designed to test Hypotheses 1–3, with an individual difference as the moderator. Experiment 2 was designed to test Hypotheses 4–6, using a situation variable as the moderator.

The pilot study

Past research has compared consumers' attitudes towards product advertising and CRM but not sponsorship and CRM (Meenaghan 2001b). Therefore, a pilot study was conducted to test the proposed difference assumption and compare perceptions and attitudes towards CRM with those towards sponsorship.

Participants and procedures

Eighty university students were recruited and paid for their participation. Their attitudes towards CRM and sponsorship were measured without any ad exposure. They completed a self-administered survey that contained an open-ended question probing their perceptions of either sponsorship or CRM, the two focal scales and several filler scales.

Materials

Half the participants read an explanation of sponsorship and listed the thoughts that sponsorship prompted. The other half read an explanation of CRM and listed the thoughts it prompted. All participants then read an explanation of the other corporate giving strategy they had not written about and completed two 7-item Likert scales designed to assess their attitudes towards sponsorship and CRM. The items were: 'I like sponsorship/CRM', 'Sponsorship/CRM needs consumer support', 'Sponsorship/CRM deserves consumer support', 'Sponsorship/CRM is believable', 'Sponsorship/CRM is good', 'Sponsorship/CRM should be allowed' and 'Sponsorship/CRM is altruistic' (Cronbach's alpha = 0.89 for sponsorship and 0.92 for CRM). For both scales, the factor analysis with Varimax rotation yielded one factor with an eigenvalue greater than 1 (sponsorship eigenvalue = 3.88, 64.67% of variance explained; CRM eigenvalue = 4.34, 72.24% of variance explained). In each case, the responses to the seven items were averaged to create a scale score.

Coding

The open-ended responses were coded by two independent coders unaware of the purpose of the study. The coding units were sentences. Responses were first coded by valence (e.g. positive: 'it is good for companies to be involved in causes'; negative: 'I am suspicious of such activities'; neutral: 'such activities are getting more common'). All thoughts were further coded as attributive or non-attributive. Among the attributive thoughts, additional categories distinguished them as related to external causes (e.g. 'advertisers are simply using these causes to manipulate consumers'), internal causes (e.g. 'a company supports a cause because it cares') or mixed (e.g. 'even though a company may support a cause because it cares, it also supports it to improve image or bring in more profits'). The two coders each coded one-third of the responses independently to check for intercoder reliability. The Krippendorff's (1980) α was 0.93 for thought valence and 0.86 for attributiveness, indicating good intercoder reliability. The coders resolved any disagreements through discussion and split the remaining two-thirds of the responses.

Results

Participants in the CRM and sponsorship conditions did not differ in the total number of thoughts they listed, $F(1, 78) = 0.45$, $p = 0.51$, $\eta_p^2 < 0.01$, $M_{\text{CRM}} = 7.20$, $SD = 3.69$,

$M_{sponsor}$ = 6.63, SD = 3.98. However, CRM participants listed more negative thoughts than the sponsorship participants, $F(1, 78) = 4.49$, $p = 0.04$, $\eta_p^2 = 0.05$, M_{CRM} = 2.50, SD = 2.31, $M_{sponsor}$ = 1.43, SD = 2.23, though the groups did not differ in the number of positive, $F(1, 78) = 0.09$, $p = 0.77$, $\eta_p^2 < 0.01$, M_{CRM} = 3.35, SD = 2.78, $M_{sponsor}$ = 3.18, SD = 2.48, or neutral, $F(1, 78) = 2.99$, $p = 0.09$, $\eta_p^2 = 0.04$, M_{CRM} = 1.35, SD = 1.44, $M_{sponsor}$ = 2.03, SD = 2.01, thoughts. Those in the CRM condition listed similar numbers of negative and positive thoughts, $t(39) = 1.40$, $p = 0.17$, whereas those in the sponsorship condition listed more positive than negative thoughts, $t(39) = 3.00$, $p = 0.01$. These results suggested that participants had ambivalent perceptions of CRM but more favourable views of sponsorship, in support of the assumptions underlying this study.

Participants in the CRM condition also produced more attributive thoughts, $F(1, 78) = 5.36$, $p = 0.02$, $\eta_p^2 = 0.06$, M_{CRM} = 1.55, SD = 1.74, $M_{sponsor}$ = 0.78, SD = 1.21, but they only listed significantly more external attributive thoughts than sponsorship participants, $F(1, 78) = 7.00$, $p < 0.01$, $\eta_p^2 = 0.08$, M_{CRM} = 0.68, SD = 0.83, $M_{sponsor}$ = 0.25, SD = 0.59, not more internal attributive thoughts, $F(1, 78) = 0.66$, $p = 0.42$, $\eta_p^2 = 0.01$, M_{CRM} = 0.48, SD = 0.72, $M_{sponsor}$ = 0.35, SD = 0.66. Moreover, those in the CRM condition listed similar numbers of external and internal attributive thoughts, $t(39) = 1.16$, $p = 0.23$. Even though respondents in the sponsorship condition listed more internal than external thoughts, the difference was not significant, $t(39) = 0.70$, $p = 0.49$. It is important to note that the means for internal and external attributive thoughts in the sponsorship condition were low, probably because consumers did not feel ambivalent towards sponsorship and thus were less likely to engage in motive attribution.

Finally, attitudes towards sponsorship were more positive than attitudes towards CRM, $t(79) = 2.28$, $p = 0.03$, $M_{sponsorship}$ = 5.55, SD = 1.01, M_{CRM} = 5.22, SD = 1.21, as expected.

Experiment 1

Participants and design

University students (N = 128; 50% male) were recruited and paid for their participation. The experiment was a 2 (corporate giving style: sponsorship versus CRM) × 2 (product use frequency: heavy versus light) between-subjects factorial design.

Procedures

One hundred and twenty-eight students who responded to a recruitment email ad completed a product use frequency scale and several filler scales. Their responses categorised them as heavy, regular or light product users (N = 64 for each category). Heavy and light users were then contacted to participate in the main experiment and randomly assigned to one of the two corporate giving style conditions. Participants read two magazine articles, followed (in order) by one filler ad, the target ad and a second filler ad. They completed scales assessing brand attitudes, emotional involvement with the cause, ad attention, elaboration involvement and product use frequency.

Materials

Professional copy writers and designers created the ads, which were pretested to ensure successful message manipulation. To improve external validity, in each condition the stimuli ads were inserted after two magazine articles and between two real filler ads. The magazine articles and filler ads were also pretested to ensure they did not evoke emotional reactions. Credit cards, an industry often associated with sponsorship and CRM, were selected as the target product. To increase perceived relevance to the college student sample, the ads conveyed that the card was designed specifically for college students. Because pre-existing interest in and familiarity with a cause can influence the effectiveness of CRM and sponsorship (D'Astous & Bitz 1995; Lafferty *et al.* 2004; Lafferty & Goldsmith 2005), a fictitious cause was created to reduce any potential confounds. A special concert for handicapped young adults was chosen as the target cause; it would work well for either sponsorship or CRM. All ads featured the same credit card attributes. To reduce the effects of pre-existing attitudes towards a company or brand, which might moderate the influence of CRM and sponsorship (Stipp & Schiavone 1996; Johar & Pham 1999; Pham & Johar 2001; Dean 2003; Lafferty *et al*. 2004), the issuing bank was fictitious, introduced as a foreign bank that would be establishing branch offices in the focal market.

Independent variables

Corporate giving style: sponsorship versus CRM

The sponsorship ad stated that the company had signed up to sponsor a special concert for handicapped young adults. The CRM ad stated that the company had signed up to donate a fixed amount of money to the concert for each transaction charged on the company's student credit cards. One of the following yes–no recognition statements was included to ensure that participants could tell the purpose of the ad: 'The ad mentioned that the company has agreed to sponsor a special concert' or 'The ad mentioned that the company has agreed to donate money for the concert each time consumers charge on the card.' A majority of respondents in both the sponsorship (88.75%) and CRM (96.70%) conditions answered affirmatively.

Product use frequency: heavy versus light users

In the recruiting stage, participants indicated, on a 7-point Likert scale, the degree to which they agreed with each of the following statements: 'I charge most of my purchases on credit cards' and 'I am a heavy user of credit cards' (Cronbach's alpha = 0.90). Heavy users scored higher on the product use frequency scale than light users, $F(1, 123) = 519.97$, $p = 0.01$. To eliminate the potential confound of available spending money, participants also reported the average amount of money they spent each month. The difference in spending between heavy and light users was not significant though, $F(1, 123) = 2.31$, $p = 0.14$, suggesting that heavy and light users differed in how frequently they used their credit cards but not in how much they spent overall.

Dependent variables

As a measure of *emotional involvement* with the cause, participants indicated on a 7-point Likert scale their agreement with three statements, developed for this study: 'I felt warm-hearted thinking about the event', 'I was moved thinking about the event' and 'I became emotional thinking about the event' (Cronbach's alpha = 0.97, mean = 4.47, *SD* = 1.39). For their *brand attitudes*, the participants rated their agreement with four items adopted from Holbrook and Batra (1987): 'good', 'likeable', 'positive' and 'favourable' (Cronbach's alpha = 0.91, mean = 4.20, *SD* = 1.09).

Covariates: ad attention and elaboration involvement

To create a viewing context that was similar to a natural setting, the participants were told that the purpose of the study was to understand how consumers evaluated magazine layouts and comprehended articles. They might thus pay only passing attention to the inserted ads, as they usually would when reading magazines at home. Therefore, ad attention (Cronbach's alpha = 0.88, mean = 3.88, *SD* = 1.42) and evaluation involvement (Cronbach's alpha = 0.85, mean = 4.22, *SD* = 1.32), adopted from Laczniak and Muehling (1993), appeared as covariates in all analyses.

Results

An ANCOVA with ad attention and elaboration involvement as covariates indicated a significant interaction effect between corporate giving style and product use frequency on emotional involvement with the cause, $F(1, 124) = 5.49$, $p = 0.02$, $\eta_p^2 = 0.04$, as Table 1 shows. The heavy users reported greater emotional involvement with the cause than did the light users for the CRM ads, $F(1, 61) = 7.25$, $p = 0.01$, $\eta_p^2 = 0.11$, $M_{\text{heavy}} = 4.86$,

Table 1: ANCOVA results from Experiment 1 and Experiment 2

	Emotional involvement			Brand attitudes		
	F	*p*	η_p^2	*F*	*p*	η_p^2
Attention	0.42	0.52	0.01	4.39	0.04	0.04
Elaboration involvement	0.29	0.59	0.01	1.34	0.25	0.01
Corporate giving style (C)	0.18	0.67	0.01	0.14	0.71	0.01
Product use frequency (F)	3.44	0.07	0.03	0.47	0.49	0.01
C × F	5.49	0.02	0.04	4.78	0.03	0.04
	Attributions of motives			**Brand attitudes**		
	F	*p*	η_p^2	*F*	*p*	η_p^2
Affect intensity	2.20	0.14	0.02	1.50	0.22	0.01
Corporate giving style (C)	1.72	0.19	0.01	0.01	0.92	0.01
Evoked affective (A)	0.10	0.76	0.01	1.56	0.21	0.01
C × A	3.76	0.06	0.03	2.30	0.13	0.02

SD = 1.40, M_{light} = 3.95, SD = 1.40, according to the results in Table 2. In contrast, this individual difference did not influence emotional involvement with the cause for the sponsorship ads, $F(1, 77) = 0.23$, $p = 0.64$, $\eta_p^2 = 0.01$, M_{heavy} = 4.49, SD = 1.47, M_{light} = 4.56, SD = 1.19, in support of Hypothesis 1.

There was also a significant interaction between corporate giving style and product usage frequency for brand attitudes, $F(1, 124) = 4.78$, $p = 0.03$, $\eta_p^2 = 0.04$. Consistent with this study's expectations, for CRM ads, the heavy users' brand attitudes were more favourable than those of light users, $F(1, 61) = 5.34$, $p = 0.02$, $\eta_p^2 = 0.08$, M_{heavy} = 4.49, SD = 1.03, M_{light} = 3.95, SD = 1.03. In contrast, the brand attitudes of heavy and light users did not differ for sponsorship ads, $F(1, 61) = 1.28$, $p = 0.26$, $\eta_p^2 = 0.02$, M_{heavy} = 4.07, SD = 1.28, M_{light} = 4.29, SD = 0.98, in support of Hypothesis 2.

Regression analyses tested the mediational role of emotional involvement, using the procedures described by Baron and Kenny (1986). When emotional involvement was regressed on corporate giving style, use frequency and the interaction term, the interaction accounted for significant variance in emotional involvement, $\beta = 0.21$, $p = 0.02$. When brand attitudes were regressed on corporate giving style, use frequency, and the interaction term, the interaction term was a significant predictor, $\beta = 0.20$, $p = 0.03$. In addition, emotional involvement predicted brand attitudes, $\beta = 0.55$, $p < 0.01$. Finally, when brand attitudes were regressed on corporate giving style, use frequency, the interaction term and emotional involvement, the effect of the interaction term was not significant, $\beta = 0.08$, $p = 0.29$, whereas the effect of emotional involvement remained significant, $\beta = 0.54$, $p < 0.01$. A Sobel test showed that the effect of the interaction term decreased significantly

Table 2: Means and results of simple effects tests for product use frequency and ad-evoked affect groups

	Experiment 1									
	CRM					Sponsorship				
	Heavy users	Light users	Simple effects			Heavy users	Light users	Simple effects		
	M (*SD*)	*M* (*SD*)	*F*	*p*	η_p^2	*M* (*SD*)	*M* (*SD*)	*F*	*p*	η_p^2
Emotional involvement	4.86 (1.40)	3.95 (1.40)	7.25	0.01	0.11	4.49 (1.47)	4.56 (1.19)	0.23	0.63	0.01
Brand attitudes	4.49 (1.03)	3.95 (1.03)	5.34	0.02	0.08	4.07 (1.28)	4.29 (0.98)	1.28	0.26	0.02
	Experiment 2									
	CRM					Sponsorship				
	Positive affect	Neutral affect	Simple effects			Positive affect	Neutral affect	Simple effects		
	M (*SD*)	*M* (*SD*)	*F*	*p*	η_p^2	*M* (*SD*)	*M* (*SD*)	*F*	*p*	η_p^2
Attributions of motives	5.04 (0.86)	4.63 (1.04)	2.99	0.09	0.05	4.39 (1.11)	4.68 (1.17)	1.14	0.29	0.02
Brand attitudes	4.64 (1.31)	4.03 (1.20)	3.92	0.05	0.06	4.23 (1.34)	4.28 (1.22)	0.03	0.86	0.01

when emotional involvement was included in the analysis ($Z = 2.23$, $p = 0.01$). Thus emotional involvement met the criteria as a mediator of the relationship between the interaction (product use frequency by corporate giving style) and brand attitudes, in support of Hypothesis 3.

Discussion

The interaction between corporate giving style and product use frequency had a significant impact on emotional involvement and brand attitudes. Emotional involvement, a stimuli-triggered response rather than an existing consumer difference, also mediated the effect of this interaction on brand attitudes. Thus, Experiment 1 showed that individual differences moderate the influence of two corporate giving styles. Experiment 2 in turn was designed to test whether situational factors, such as affective states, also moderate the influence of corporate giving style.

Experiment 2

Participants, design, materials, and procedures

Similar to Experiment 1, university students ($N = 128$; 50% male) were recruited and paid for their participation. The experiment was a 2 (corporate giving style: sponsorship versus CRM) × 2 (ad-evoked affect: positive versus neutral) between-subjects factorial design. The procedures were identical to those used in Experiment 1, except for the measures. After reading the two magazine articles, the first filler ad, the target ad and the second filler ad, participants completed scales designed to assess their brand attitudes, attribution of motivations/causes, ad-evoked affect and affect intensity.

Independent variables

Corporate giving style: sponsorship versus CRM

The manipulation was the same as in Experiment 1.

Ad-evoked affective states: positive versus neutral

Ads in the positive affective state condition featured the personal story of a young handicapped man who was scheduled to perform in a concert. The story related how the man was born blind and with a special talent for music. He faced his disability with optimism, worked especially hard to become a pianist, and inspired others with his high spirits. The tone of the story was positive, uplifting and encouraging. Ads in the neutral condition only noted the importance of the event for handicapped people and did not include any encouraging personal story. Five items were adopted from Matthews, Jones and Chamberlain (1990) to measure ad-evoked affect. On a 7-point Likert scale, participants indicated the degree to which they experienced the following emotions when reading the ads: 'pleased', 'cheerful', 'happy', 'satisfied' and 'contented' (Cronbach's alpha = 0.94). As expected, participants in the positive affect condition reported that the ad made them feel more positive than did those in the neutral condition, $F(1, 126) = 3.90$, $p = 0.05$, $M_{pos} = 4.68$, $SD = 1.34$, $M_{neu} = 4.24$, $SD = 1.16$. Therefore, the manipulation was deemed satisfactory.

Dependent variables

Attribution of motives

Attribution scales should be domain specific, so the items were developed specifically for this experiment. Using the definitions of external and internal attributions from advertising literature (e.g. Smith & Hunt 1978), four items served to assess external and internal attribution: 'The company is trying to mislead consumers into believing in its goodwill'; 'The company is using the cause to lure consumers into applying for or using its cards'; 'The company wants to contribute to society'; and 'The company is doing good for society.' A factor analysis with Varimax rotation yielded only one factor with an eigenvalue greater than 1 (eigenvalue = 2.39, 59.82% of variance explained). Therefore, the scores for the four items (reversed for external attribution) were averaged, with larger numbers indicating greater internal attributions (Cronbach's alpha = 0.79, mean = 4.69, *SD* = 1.06).

Brand attitudes

The scale was identical to that used in Experiment 1 (Cronbach's alpha = 0.93), and the scores for the four items were averaged (mean = 4.30, *SD* = 1.27).

Covariate: affect intensity

People vary in terms of the strength of their emotional experiences (Diener *et al*. 1985), a characteristic referred to as affect intensity. According to Moore and Harris (1996), people with high affect intensity have more favourable attitudes towards positive emotional ad appeals than participants with low affect intensity. Therefore, participants in this experiment used a 7-point Likert scale to respond to Larsen's (1984) affect intensity scale (Cronbach's alpha = 0.74, mean = 4.63, *SD* = 1.35).

Results

An ANCOVA indicated that the interaction between corporate giving style and ad-evoked affect for attribution approached significance, $F(1, 123) = 3.76, p = 0.06, \eta_p^2 = 0.03$ (see Table 1). Positive affect enhanced attributions of internal motivations for CRM ads more than did neutral affect, but as Table 2 shows, the effect only approached significance, $F(1, 61) = 2.99, p = 0.09, \eta_p^2 = 0.05, M_{pos} = 5.04, SD = 0.86, M_{neu} = 4.63, SD = 1.04$. As expected, affect type did not alter attributions for sponsorship ads, $F(1, 61) = 1.14$, $p = 0.29, \eta_p^2 = 0.02, M_{pos} = 4.39, SD = 1.11, M_{neu} = 4.68, SD = 1.17$.

The interaction between corporate giving style and ad-evoked affect on brand attitudes was not significant, $F(1, 123) = 2.30, p = 0.13, \eta_p^2 = 0.02$. However, simple effects tests demonstrated that positive affect led to significantly more favourable attitudes towards the brand in CRM ads than did neutral affect, $F(1, 61) = 3.92, p = 0.05, M_{pos} = 4.64$, $\eta_p^2 = 0.06, SD = 1.31, M_{neu} = 4.03, SD = 1.20$. In contrast, affect valence did not alter attitudes towards the brand in sponsorship ads, $F(1, 61) = 0.03, p = 0.86, \eta_p^2 < 0.01$, $M_{pos} = 4.23, SD = 1.34, M_{neu} = 4.28, SD = 1.22$. Thus, only the simple effects results fully supported Hypothesis 5.

The test of the mediational role of attribution of motivations used the same procedures as in Experiment 1. When attribution was regressed on corporate giving style, ad-evoked affect and the interaction term, the interaction was a marginally significant predictor, $\beta = 0.17$, $p = 0.06$. When brand attitudes were regressed on corporate giving style, ad-evoked affect and the interaction term, the interaction was not significant, $\beta = 0.14$, $p = 0.11$. However, attribution significantly predicted brand attitudes, $\beta = 0.64$, $p < 0.01$, and when brand attitudes were regressed on corporate giving style, ad-evoked affect, the interaction term and attribution, the effect of the interaction term on brand attitudes was significantly reduced, $\beta = 0.03$, $p = 0.63$, but the effect of attribution remained significant, $\beta = 0.64$, $p < 0.01$. A Sobel test showed that the effect of the interaction decreased significantly when attribution was included in the analysis ($Z = 1.90$, $p = 0.03$).

Discussion

Although the effect of the interaction between corporate giving style and ad-evoked affect on attribution was not significant (probably due to the small sample size and low power), the means suggested that positive participants made relatively more internal attributions for CRM ads than did neutral participants. The effect of the same interaction on brand attitudes was not significant, yet the results of the simple effects tests were consistent with expectations; positive participants reported more favourable brand attitudes than neutral participants for CRM ads.

General discussion

Findings and contributions

Corporate giving comes in various forms, including philanthropy, sponsorship and CRM (Burlingame 2001; Polonsky & Speed 2001), which vary in the altruistic intent they invoke (Webb & Mohr 1998). Although both sponsorship and CRM can contribute to society as a whole, the sales orientation of CRM draws more criticism than the branding orientation of sponsorship (Webb & Mohr 1998). Until now, however, no empirical research has compared perceptions of these two corporate giving strategies or the effectiveness of ads that leverage them.

The pilot study analysis showed that consumers hold ambivalent attitudes towards CRM but positive attitudes towards sponsorship. Noting these ambivalent perceptions of CRM, this paper has presented a contingency model, in which the effectiveness of CRM, but not that of sponsorship, depends on product use frequency and ad-induced affect. The proposed mechanisms explaining the effects of CRM and empirically tested mediators have illuminated the processes driving this phenomenon.

Product use frequency increases emotional involvement with the cause, as borne out by the findings of Experiment 1, in which heavy product users became more emotionally involved with the cause, probably in their effort to reduce feelings of guilt, than did light users. In the process, they probably experienced lesser activation of negative perceptions of CRM as manipulative and sales orientated. Therefore, the heavy users responded more positively to brands that used CRM advertising. In contrast, heavy and light users did not differ in their emotional involvement with a cause promoted by sponsorship;

probably because the sponsorship contributions did not hinge on consumer purchasing behaviour.

Emotional stories often appear in advertising that leverages corporate giving, to emphasise the importance of the donation. The findings of Experiment 2 suggested that, among consumers viewing CRM ads, the elicitation of positive affect through heart-warming real-life stories led to relatively more positive motive attributions, due to the affect priming mechanism. In the process, negative motive attributions were suppressed, which then significantly improved brand attitudes. In contrast, negative motive attributions for sponsorship were not readily accessible, so no positive story was needed to reduce their activation. Including a positive story thus did not significantly improve attitudes towards the sponsored brand.

Friestad and Wright (1994) have suggested that, over time, consumers become familiar with the persuasion strategies marketers use and that this knowledge may help them understand the strategies and alter their responses to them. It appears that consumers have developed a good understanding of the differences between sponsorship and CRM, such that they view sponsorship as less sales orientated, profit centred and instrumentally motivated than CRM. This knowledge structure might affect the way consumers evaluate a brand that adopts such strategies. Knowledge regarding CRM, but not sponsorship, is associated with an equal number of positive and negative perceptions (as shown in the pilot study). Understanding this knowledge structure difference helps explain the different mechanisms likely to be triggered by ads that leverage CRM versus sponsorship.

Further research directions

This study has shown that product use frequency increases emotional involvement with the cause, such that heavy product users become more emotionally involved with the cause, probably in an effort to reduce their feelings of guilt, compared with light users. However, this underlying guilt reduction motivation has not been specifically tested; it should be a focus of further research. Moreover, the rationale that, in their guilt reduction process, heavy users experience lesser activation of negative perceptions of CRM as manipulative and sales orientated awaits further tests.

The target audience for sponsorship and CRM has been extended, from people connected with the particular event or cause to larger consumer groups and sometimes even the general public. A primary objective of sponsorship and CRM is to increase awareness of the association between the cause and the sponsor, usually accomplished with advertising and media coverage. The two experiments in this paper thus focused on advertising that leverages sponsorship and CRM, but additional research could explore responses to media coverage. The media are generally perceived as more objective than advertisers, so media coverage could be more effective than advertising in communicating the desired information and enhancing the image of the brand and company.

Research also might extend the findings of this study by exploring different events or causes. For example, the effectiveness of a sponsorship is moderated by factors such as the congruency between the company and the sponsored event (Gwinner & Eaton 1999; Speed & Thompson 2000; Poon & Prendergast 2006), consumer involvement with the cause (Madrigal 2001) and knowledge about the cause (Roy & Cornwell 2004). Rifon *et al*. (2004) show that sponsoring an incongruent, as opposed to congruent, event is less likely to elicit altruistic motive attributions that influence consumers' ratings of the sponsor's credibility and attitudes. In other words, when not carefully executed, even sponsorship can be perceived as less altruistic. This possibility should be tested further.

The effectiveness of CRM also depends on the congruency between the company and the sponsored event or cause (Ellen *et al.* 2000; Pracejus & Olsen 2002), descriptions of the donation amounts (Olsen *et al.* 2003) and the type of product (Strahilevitz & Myers 1998). It therefore would be important to explore whether the effectiveness of CRM ads varies with the nature of the cause. Causes and events vary tremendously in the amount of goodwill they generate (Meenaghan 2001a), their importance (Lafferty 2009) and the perception of exploitation they evoke (Meenaghan 2001b). They also differ in the degree to which they involve consumers (Meenaghan 2001a). For example, charitable causes tend to involve consumers more, whether personally or emotionally, than do arts events. If certain causes and events have more enthusiasts, they may be more effective in involving consumers and encouraging them to view CRM more favourably.

This study featured product use frequency, which is salient for credit cards. For products that can only be consumed once though, frequency of purchase, rather than frequency of use, probably determines the extent of consumer contributions to a CRM programme. This distinction could be a focal comparison point for further research.

Finally, CRM may be interpreted differently in different contexts, and the relative effectiveness of sponsorship and CRM can be moderated by other factors. For example, CRM works better for frivolous than for functional products (Strahilevitz & Meyers 1998), so there may be an interaction between corporate giving style and product type. Perhaps sponsorship is equally effective for functional and frivolous products, but CRM is more effective for frivolous products because it attenuates or even transforms purchase guilt. Prior research also has suggested that CRM works better for companies with an average reputation than for those with a high reputation (Dean 2003). Many such hypotheses remain to be formulated and tested.

Managerial implications

The findings of this paper have important implications for corporations. Companies planning to display their social responsibility or enhance their image through corporate giving have multiple corporate giving options, but prior research has not firmly established their relative effectiveness. The results of the pilot study suggest that sponsorship is generally a safer strategy than CRM (because it is perceived as positive, and its effectiveness does not vary by context). However, in conditions with minimal activation of negative perceptions or attributions, CRM can be just as effective, such as when consumers are heavy product users or the ads evoke positive affect. Because CRM is closely tied to revenue, such information has great practical value.

Limitations

Some limitations should be kept in mind when interpreting and generalising these findings. First, college students may not be the primary target consumers for credit card companies. The credit card product used in the studies was introduced as a student card, which may have increased self-relevancy (as intended) without completely overcoming the potential problem of low baseline product involvement. Second, the scales developed for emotional involvement and motive attribution achieved acceptable reliability, but their validity may not be satisfactory. Third, this study explored attitudes towards the brand but not attitudes towards the ads themselves, because the ultimate goal of corporate giving activities is to enhance attitudes towards the brand. However, additional research should explore attitudes towards the ad. Despite these limitations, the findings reported herein illustrate the importance of distinguishing between forms of corporate giving and understanding the different effects of ads that leverage these forms and the underlying mechanisms that generate such differences.

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